The Growing Years

A free field guide for ages 12–17 and the adults who support them

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Build habits that can grow with you. Start with something you can do on an ordinary school day. Keep the routines that give you more energy, confidence or room to enjoy life. Bodies develop at different speeds, and skills take years of practice.

Inside · Growing at your own pace · Mouth and breathing · Movement and lifting · Food and sleep · Skin, hair and style · Your two-week card · Sources

Health note · General education reviewed 7 November 2026. Ask a trusted adult to help you find qualified care if you have symptoms or concerns. Use local emergency services if someone cannot breathe.



01 / Grow at your own pace

Puberty can change skin, hair, voice, appetite, height and strength on different timelines. A friend’s changes cannot tell you how yours should look. A selfie also changes with camera distance, lighting, expression and angle. Pick one marker you can use without a mirror: how rested you feel in class, whether you enjoy a sport, or whether you remembered sunscreen.

Try this · Mute one account that makes you feel worse after scrolling. Save one post that teaches a skill or helps you have fun. If you like a trend, pause and ask who made it, what they sell and whether a reliable source backs the claim.

Get support · If comparing, checking, avoiding food, exercising to compensate for eating, or worrying about appearance starts taking over your day, tell a trusted adult, school counselor or clinician. You deserve support early.

02 / Let your mouth rest

Mewing usually refers to deliberately holding or pressing the tongue against the roof of the mouth in the hope of changing the jaw. The American Association of Orthodontists says there is no scientific evidence that this reshapes the jawline. Forceful pressure may affect teeth and bite. Skip jaw trainers, forceful chewing and mouth taping. [1]

At rest · When nose breathing is comfortable, your lips may meet gently and your teeth can rest slightly apart. The tongue rests lightly and its tip position can vary. There is no placement score or daily drill. If your nose is blocked, breathe however you can comfortably. [2]

At meals · Sit comfortably upright, take manageable bites, chew at an easy pace until food feels ready, and let swallowing happen naturally. Teeth break food down, saliva moistens it and the tongue moves it back for swallowing. Chew counts, side quotas and tongue drills are unnecessary for a typical eater. Frequent coughing, choking, a wet-sounding voice after swallowing or food sticking need assessment. Tell an adult. [3]

Who can help · A dentist or orthodontist can assess teeth, bite or jaw pain. A clinician or ENT can check ongoing blockage, mouth breathing, loud snoring or breathing pauses. A speech-language pathologist can assess chewing or swallowing. Brush with fluoride toothpaste twice daily and clean between teeth daily with advice from your dental team. [2–4, 11]

03 / Move in ways you enjoy

For ages 5–17, WHO recommends an average of 60 minutes of moderate-to-vigorous activity per day across the week, mostly aerobic, and vigorous and muscle- and bone-strengthening activity at least three days a week. Walking briskly, dancing, playing, cycling and sports can contribute. If you are starting with less, build up gradually. An active day does not have to be a gym day. [5]

A first supervised session · With a qualified coach and a parent or caregiver aware of the plan, warm up with five minutes of easy movement. Try an unloaded sit-to-stand, an incline push-up, a light band row and a hip hinge. Begin with one easy set of 8–12 controlled reps where appropriate. Rest as needed. Ask the coach to help you choose equipment that fits and a comfortable range. Start with one or two sessions on nonconsecutive days and build at your pace. Keep school sport and recovery in the plan. [6]

For a long school day · Put both feet somewhere supported, move the screen where you can read it and change position between tasks. Walk a little or try a few easy sit-to-stands if comfortable. Seek help for persistent pain. Stop a session and tell an adult if you feel sharp pain, dizziness, chest pain or unusual trouble breathing. [6, 7]

04 / Eat, sleep and recover

Regular meals and snacks can help cover the energy needed for school, movement and growth. Try pairing an energy food (rice, bread, oats or potatoes) with a protein food (beans, tofu, eggs, yogurt, fish or meat) and add fruit or vegetables as available. Drink water regularly. Examples include rice and beans with peppers, yogurt and fruit with oats, and a hummus sandwich with a piece of fruit. Culture, allergies and food access shape what works. For dietary concerns, talk with a caregiver and a pediatric clinician or dietitian. [8]

Sleep · At age 12, aim for 9–12 hours in 24 hours. Ages 13–17 generally need 8–10 hours. Pick a regular wake time and work backward to a bedtime that gives you enough time. Try dimming lights and leaving your phone out of reach as you get ready. Ongoing tiredness, frequent loud snoring and breathing pauses deserve a conversation with an adult and a clinician. [9, 11]

At the gym · Bring water, plan time for food afterward, and give sore muscles a chance to recover. Skip stimulant pre-workouts, fat burners and appearance-driven dieting.

05 / Make care simple

Skin · Use a mild cleanser and lukewarm water. Wash gently after sweating. Add a moisturizer if skin feels dry, and use broad-spectrum, water-resistant SPF 30 or higher on exposed skin outdoors, plus shade or clothing. Follow the label for reapplication. Painful acne, scarring or a rash that persists deserves advice from a clinician. [10]

Hair · Wash your scalp as needed for your hair and activity. Conditioner can help on the lengths, especially if hair is dry or curly. Detangle gently, use less heat and loosen styles that pull. If you notice sudden patches of hair loss or a sore scalp, tell an adult. [12]

Style · Pick clothes you can sit, reach and move in. Build an outfit from what you already have. Try comfortable shoes, a top you like and a layer for the weather. Take care of clothes and shoes so they last. No photo or body measurement is needed.

06 / Your two-week card

Choose one action. Write the cue and the smallest version you can do on a tough day. Check in after two weeks and keep, shrink or change it.

Example · After packing my school bag, I put my phone on the charger away from my bed. If I forget, I try again the next evening.

My action _____

My cue _____

Small version _____

How it felt after two weeks _____

Who can support me _____

For caregivers · Ask what the young person wants to learn. Model rest, food and movement without body talk. Help arrange a dental, medical, speech-language or coaching assessment when useful. Keep worksheets private and offline. Do not use them to grade a young person’s body.

Source notes

Editorial review · 7 November 2026. Numbers match the references in the text. Select a title to open the original guidance.

[1] American Association of Orthodontists · Is Mewing Bad for You?

[2] ASHA · Orofacial Myofunctional Disorders

[3] ASHA · Pediatric Feeding and Swallowing

[4] American Dental Association · Home Oral Care

[5] World Health Organization · Physical Activity by Age

[6] American Academy of Pediatrics · Resistance Training for Children and Adolescents

[7] Cambridge University Hospitals · Posture, Core Stability and Lifting

[8] World Health Organization · Healthy Diet

[9] NIH / NHLBI · How Much Sleep Is Enough?

[10] American Academy of Dermatology · Skin Care for Acne-Prone Skin

[11] NIH / NHLBI · Sleep Apnea Symptoms

[12] American Academy of Dermatology · Tips for Healthy Hair